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Critical Reflection

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Critical Reflection on Equity,Access, and Ethical Responsibility in Technical Communication

There is a question that has quietly accompanied every project I completed throughout this portfolio: Who is technical communication actually for? The deeper I moved into the work of crafting leadership presentations, researching healthcare communication barriers, and examining algorithmic bias in artificial intelligence, the more I understood that technical communication is never a neutral act. The portfolio I have assembled is not simply a collection of completed assignments; it is a sustained argument that communication is one of the most powerful tools we have for either reinforcing or dismantling systems of inequity. Walton, Moore, and Jones capture this responsibility precisely: technical communicators who choose not to consider social justice are working not only ineffectively but unjustly, and are doing harm (2019). That warning became the compass for everything that followed.

My Client Project, completed at Tennessee Tech University's Office of Intercultural Affairs, placed me directly inside the work of leadership development for first-year and international students. Drawing on Komives, Lucas, and McMahon's Leadership Identity Development Model, I recognized early that students develop leadership identity through social interaction, reflection, and meaningful engagement rather than through passive instruction. This shaped how I designed my presentations. Rather than delivering information from the front of the room, I invited students into the process through interactive activities where they named their personal leadership values and reflected on how those values connect to mentorship and community. Littlejohn and Foss deepened this approach by reminding me that communication is the primary process through which humans build shared meaning (2021), which means leadership programs are not neutral spaces; they either open or close doors depending on whose voices are centered. Astin's Theory of Student Involvement further reinforced that meaningful development requires both physical and psychological investment, and that first-generation and international students are most at risk of disengagement when programs fail to account for their cultural contexts (1984). My work in that office was, in the language of social justice technical communication, an act of deliberate inclusion.

My first digital artifact, "Bridging the Technological Access Gap: The Critical Role of Communication Training in Healthcare Delivery," extended this line of inquiry into healthcare. What became clear through this project is that the failures of digital health implementation are not primarily technological; they are communication failures. Pagano's concept of health communication as relational and contextual was central to my argument: effective healthcare delivery requires genuine responsiveness to patients' circumstances, not simply the efficient transfer of information (2019). Wang et al., research made the inequity concrete, showing how the gap between those who can and cannot access digital health tools maps almost exactly onto existing lines of racial, economic, and geographic disadvantage (2011). Patient education initiatives, as I argued, function as surface-level responses. They treat symptoms without addressing the root cause, which is the systemic failure to train providers in equitable, patient-centered communication. This paper sharpened a realization I had first encountered in my Client Project: the populations most likely to be underserved are always those who already carry the heaviest structural disadvantages, and ethical technical communication must design with those people at the center, not the margins.

My second digital artifact brought this argument into its most contested terrain. Drawing on Joy Buolamwini's concept of the "coded gaze," I examined how AI systems do not simply reflect the world but actively amplify existing social inequities through biased design (2023). Hiring algorithms, facial recognition systems, and educational technologies that encode discrimination are not anomalies; they are the predictable outcomes of systems built without adequate representation or ethical accountability. The project directly engaged the argument by Fernandes and McIntyre that educators should refuse generative AI in classrooms as a form of resistance (2025). I took those concerns seriously, but ultimately argued that refusal is not protection. Students will encounter AI across every domain of their academic and professional lives, and to leave them without the tools to critically engage with these systems is to leave them more vulnerable, not less. AI literacy, in the framework I developed, is justice work. It gives students the capacity to recognize bias, question outputs, and advocate for ethical technology rather than simply being shaped by it.

Looking across all three components, what I find most meaningful is not simply that each project addresses equity and access, but that together they build a coherent argument about what ethical technical communication requires. It requires designing for the people most likely to be excluded. It requires treating communication as relational rather than purely instrumental. It requires interrogating the systems within which we work, whether those are healthcare platforms, campus leadership programs, or artificial intelligence. And it requires resisting the fiction that technical communication can be practiced without politics. I came into this program understanding that in the abstract. I leave it having tested it in practice, across real communities and real stakes.

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